

• Interview

Who needs Reformation Radio or Radio Jockeys? Let's hear about it all from RJ Atiq

We are living in the modern era of media where visuals are everything. Truly an era of “*Jo Dikhega vo Bikega*”. An audio-centric media industry like radio has several fingers on its future. Meanwhile Centre head of Radio City Vadodara has all the answers. He responds by saying,



“This very fact that a lot of people say that the radio is not working. I have been hearing it for the last 10 years. It's not working till now. And it's not going to stop.”

He promises radio reformation by changing the radio industry into an agency that attracts clients to promote their products to radio listeners. He goes on to explain, “So if there is a client who comes and tells us that I want to promote my phone, this is a phone that I'm manufacturing and I want to promote it. We'll put the ads on the radio. We have a dedicated social media team. So, they will create beautiful reels around the phone which will be there on Radio City, Instagram, and Facebook page. The RJs are

the OG influencers, right? Because they had followings long before social media came into the picture, right? So, they are the OG influencers. We'll use the RJs to sell the product.”

On the other hand, when a question was asked about the popularity of RJs, He said, “So, when I say they are not famous, a famous RJ would be somebody who's being followed or who's being heard by age group of, across all age groups. So, you know, the youngsters are also, they know about it. The oldies also know about it.” He exemplified his old Colleague Malishka, who is a well-known RJ. “So, that's what a famous RJ is because she's famous across all the age brackets.” He added.

A Question about his views on Genz's little to no consumption of Radio was answered as “It is not because whatever my interaction with all the Gen Zs and the current generation that is there. It is there. And it has a lot to do with, there are certain shortcomings, of the medium itself. And there are certain shortcomings from the authorities also. And the third one I would of course put on the owners of these radio stations.”

What are these Shortcomings that obstruct the growth of the radio arena according to Mr. Atiq?

“The shortcoming of the medium is that it is **only and only audio medium**. The world has sound moved beyond that, right? Now, everything is visual unless and until you don't have a face value for it, it's not consumed. To the extent that if you see a lot of shitty content on social media, just because that person's face is attractive or good-looking, it's trending. But some people are creating amazing content. But they don't have the face or they don't have that physical appearance to back it”

He regarded **government guidelines** as one of the shortcomings as well, “We (Radio industry consolidation) have been representing the authorities, to the government, to allow private radio stations to start news. But we still have not got the permission” The Government has been

Hesitant about this move because of “News Regulation Concerns” which Atiq doesn't consider to be fair.

Atiq validates his point further by saying “And just to counter-argue the entire thing is that you know, when COVID happened, the most consumed

media was radio. Why? Because radio was at that particular point of time, the only medium which was giving credible news, right? RJs come with a lot of credibility. So, when someone,



when an RJ says that drink Pepsi, people will follow it. Why? **Because RJ comes with the credibility.** Unlike others, if you receive news on WhatsApp, you might have doubts, about how credible it is, right? But then the same news, if an RJ comes and tells on the radio, there is a lot of credibility and you will believe that news because RJ comes with credibility.”

“Now the third comes **the owners of the radio channels.** My radio station or any radio station, if you look at all the radio stations in India, 98% or even I would go to an extent of 99% of the radio channels in India follow the same format. It's called a contemporary hit station, CHS. What is a contemporary hit station? We'll play songs which are contemporarily hit. The RJ will come and talk for, you know, one minute or one and a half minutes. There will be funny liners. There is no experimentation. There is no genre based. There is no specialization in radio”.

He even questions the radio industry by saying, “Unfortunately, here in India, the owners have yet to take the risk of going and doing something and dedicating an entire channel for that particular genre or for that particular topic. **Why can't we have a radio channel which talks only and only about sports? Why can't we have a radio channel that talks only and only about cookery? Why can't we have a radio station that talks only and only about Carnatic music? Why can't we have a radio channel that talks only and only about folk music?** It's not that we don't have the database or we don't have the material for it.

RJ demonstrates his shows, ‘Character Dissector’ and ‘Brand Tales’, and shares his journey from a copywriter to an RJ.

From learning what a copywriter is from Amul city- Anand to joining FJC, Baroda, Atiq claims always to be a creative head. He experienced Mumbai life while he wrote Gags for Raju Srivastava, scripted for Emotional Attyachar even wrote A south Indian TV serial. In the end, he came back home and worked with Red FM, Mirchi, and Fever FM.

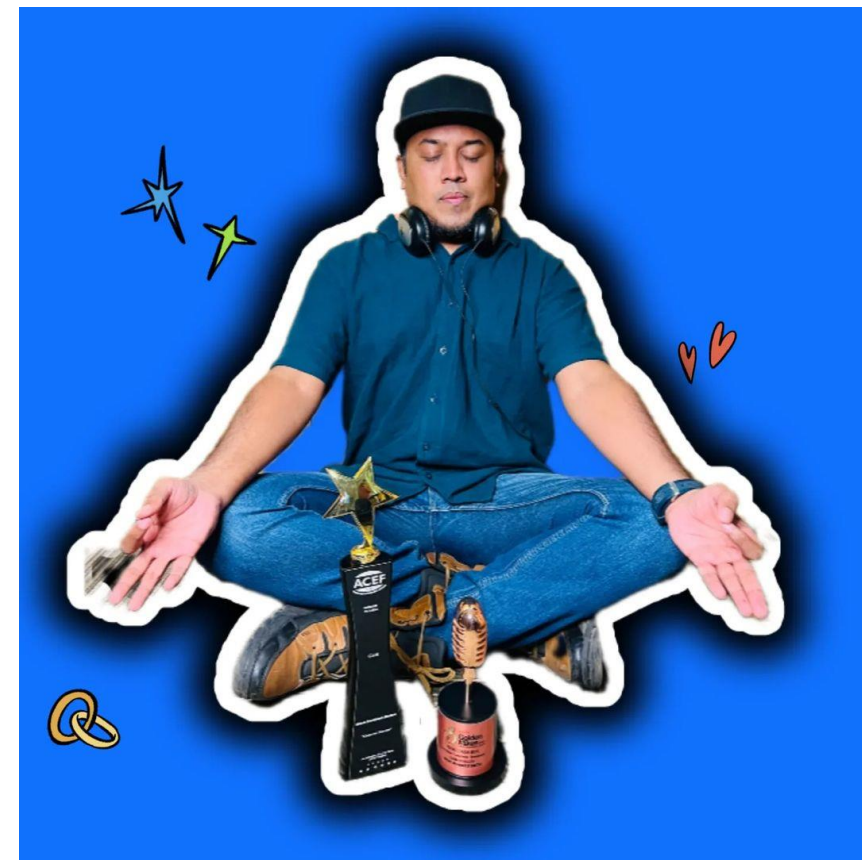
“But you will always come back to your home, right? So then finally I moved back to Baroda. At that particular time, there was no opening here in Baroda. But there was an opening at Radio City Ahmedabad. So, I was at Radio City Ahmedabad for two years. And then finally, the guy

Who was working here was heading here, was from Ahmedabad. And I was heading to Ahmedabad and I was with him. So, we then exchanged. So, then I came back to Baroda.”

“Radio was only and only music. Now our strategy has changed wherein we are now giving more importance to content than music. So, we have started creating more content. Content that is consumable for all generations.” Following the same strategy Atiq came “Parde ke piche se, Parde ke Aage”.

When he couldn't find a sample voice for his new show idea, he went ahead and recorded it by himself, and the show “Character Dissector” was his with no plan of him being RJ. He said that to does not have an ideal RJ voice but he surely has worked on his voice a lot and hence gained fan appreciation in messages.

Crime Master Gogo his favorite character inspired the show where he was able to see the characters beyond the cinema and story-line, how would they be after the film ends. The film talks with his friends inspired him to create the show. The hit show has won several awards including from Platforms like Spotify, however, he says with showing utmost- modesty that his journey has just started and he is still learning from his fellow RJs.



Another Show in the making named ‘Brand Tales’ that tells the story of the origin of various brands has already reached the brand owners, and RJ’s effort was praised.

The question concerning the Brand Image or Face Value of an RJ was answered by Atiq with, “They (RJs) have to be presentable enough. They have to be well... If you look at any of the RJs right now, they are well-groomed. They are well dressed. They

have a smart personality. They are outgoing. These are the things that are now a must for an RJ, now voice is not the only consideration. Now you have to have all these things. So, this is how the entire thing is now changing. How you are looking, how you are presenting yourself, whether this particular thing looks good on you or that thing looks good on you. Those are the things that are very essential for an RJ now.”

About creating his brand he said, “Frankly, as I said, I am still very new. I still have to create a brand. I have created an identity. I have yet to create a brand. The difference between both things is that my identity is what I am by nature. And a brand is how people are perceiving things about me. The brand is still in a very nascent stage. But I see a lot of people who relate to me as having something to do with films. Now again, it's a very difficult thing because if people

are relating me to films or people see me as a brand that is related to films, I need to know things about movies.”

Radio is reforming with a strategy of turning into an agency raising the question distinction between the ad agency and the new Radio. He favored radio by saying “The agency will take

10,000 different ways to reach out to an audience, wherein I already have a set audience with me. So, I have an edge over all these people. I already come with brand equity; people know me. People know Radio City. So, I already come with a lot of equity, which probably they (Ad agencies) don't.

What about this 360-degree change in the radio industry costing the old radio arena and its nostalgic legacy?

“There is no need for nostalgia. There is no need for keeping... Why do we want to be stuck with that? I'll tell you. So I teach at Navarachana University also. Last year I was having this session, wherein I asked all my students, how many of you listen to the radio? None of them raised their hands. So I said, do you know radio comes with such nostalgia that you don't know which song is going to play next? And suddenly you play a song that you might not have heard for ages. And then suddenly it brings you back to those nostalgic moments. It takes you back to that time when you were in that particular moment. So a guy raised his hand. So I said, yeah. He said, sir, our generation, frankly, we don't want nostalgia. We know what we want. We want to listen to a song. We'll go to Spotify, search for the song, etc. We don't want to get into nostalgia. We don't want to get into all those things.”

As stated by RJ Atiq, it seems the 360 change of the Radio industry will lead to the reformation of creators related to the industry involving creative heads, and formats to RJs.

Conversation with RJ Atiq served a new perspective and hopefulness for the future of the radio industry as an audio medium, however, the future is yet to be revealed.
